his way with plants and animal life, the royal home would have been insulated from many of these as well. Precaution being required against poison and serpents, only the shoots of plants such as the Ashvattha, as also ‘Jivanti, Sveta, Muskaka and Pushpavandaka’, were admissible. The fauna deemed worthy were those that apparently destroyed serpents, so ‘letting loose peacocks, ichneumons and spotted deer’ on the premises was a good idea. Similarly useful among bird life, ‘the heron becomes frantic in the proximity of poison, the pheasant becomes faint, the intoxicated cuckoo dies, the eyes of the Cakora-partridge become discoloured.’[47]

In the quarters where Ashoka and his siblings spent their growing years, there might thus have been a plethora of restrictions. What of the provisions made by their emperor-father for their education? The number of Ashoka’s siblings remains unknown, precision in such matters being difficult given the number of queens and concubines available to the king, the tendency not to count girl-children at all, and the possibility of some of the king’s female entourage being impregnated by male courtiers whose progeny became indistinguishable from the king’s. The tendency in many ancient Indian texts is therefore to offer a symbolic number indicating the virility and fertility of a regime: ‘101 sons’ is often given as a stereotypical figure, which it is in one account pertaining to the Ashokan context, where this number of offspring are said to have been born of Bindusara’s many wives.[48] The exaggeration shows in any case that many children in a polygamous royal establishment was the norm.

How they were educated remains unclear. The king himself was unlikely to have had much to do with their education since he did not see much of his family. His daily schedule as detailed in the *Arthashastra* suggests that his days and nights were divided into eight parts each. Time slots were allotted for looking into income and expenditure, the affairs of citizens and country people, military plans and a review of troops, consulting counsellors and dispatching secret agents, and even being blessed by a chief